

OpenClaw System Prompts

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1. Course Content

Course Overview

- 💡 OpenClaw adopts an innovative **"file as prompt"** architecture — AI Agent's behavior, identity, memory, tool usage rules, etc., are all defined and loaded through multiple Markdown files in the Workspace.

2. 📁 Switching Workspace

- OpenClaw's system prompts and skills are stored in: `/root/.openclaw/workspace` workspace path
- Jetson nano factory presets different workspace content in Chinese and English. The content meaning is the same, only the language differs
- Users from different regions can switch the OpenClaw workspace document language according to their needs
- Chinese workspace (prompts and skills content in Chinese)

```
cd /root/language
cp -a workspace_zh/. /root/.openclaw/workspace/
```

```
root@jetson-yahboom:~# cd language/
root@jetson-yahboom:~/language# cp -a workspace_zh/. /root/.openclaw/workspace/
root@jetson-yahboom:~/language# █
```

- English workspace (prompts and skills content in English)

```
cd /root/language
cp -a workspace_en/. /root/.openclaw/workspace/
```

```
root@jetson-yahboom:~# cd language/
root@jetson-yahboom:~/language# cp -a workspace_en/. /root/.openclaw/workspace/
root@jetson-yahboom:~/language# █
```

- After configuration, restart openclaw gateway to take effect

```
openclaw gateway restart
```

Warning

- `.workspace_en` and `.workspace_zh` hidden folders under `$HOME/.openclaw/workspace` are Chinese and English template files. It is recommended not to modify them

3. AGENTS.md

- Function Description

AGENTS.md defines the top-level specifications for how an Agent operates in the workspace.  It can be understood as the Agent's **"user manual"** — telling the Agent how to start up, how to manage memory, what things it can do, and what things it absolutely cannot do

- Content Structure

AGENTS.md mainly includes the following core sections:

Section	Description
First Run	Guide the Agent's initialization process during first startup (read BOOTSTRAP.md)
Mechanical Body	Describe the Agent's physical carrier (robotic arm, chassis, camera) and control methods
Session Startup	Specify the startup process and file reading order for each session
Memory System	Define the layered architecture of daily records and long-term memory
Red Line Rules	List absolutely prohibited behaviors (destructive commands, modifying robot program code)
Operation Standards	Distinguish between freely executable operations and operations that need to be queried first
Memory Maintenance	Memory organization and update mechanism during heartbeat

Note

-  The factory AGENTS.md prompts restrict OpenClaw from modifying robot program code

4. SOUL.md

- Function Description

SOUL.md is the Agent's **"soul" and core** . It defines the Agent's thinking methods and behavioral guidelines when facing tasks — how to control the robot body, how to find and use skills, how to plan and execute actions, and under what circumstances it should pause or refuse execution. SOUL.md shapes the core behavioral patterns of the Agent as a "robot operator".

- Working Principle

SOUL.md is read by the Agent when a session starts, serving as the underlying guiding principle for task execution. It does not specify concrete skill parameters, but rather dictates how the Agent **should approach any task with what kind of thinking process**. For example, the Agent is forcibly required to check the skill library before starting any task, and cannot execute based on feeling or memory — this habit of "checking documentation before doing things" is defined by SOUL.md.

5. IDENTITY.md

- Function Description

IDENTITY.md defines the AI Agent's **self-awareness and personality traits**. It defines who the Agent "is" — its name, personality, language style, and basic identity positioning. This file gives the Agent a consistent personality when interacting with users.

- Working Principle

During each session startup, the Agent reads IDENTITY.md and establishes "self-awareness" based on it. This information affects the Agent's tone when answering questions, the way it proactively offers help, and the style of building relationships with users. For example, an Agent set to be "friendly and gentle" will naturally use more亲和 (approachable) language expressions when replying to users.

6. HEARTBEAT.md

- Function Description

HEARTBEAT.md is the configuration file that controls the **heartbeat detection mechanism** in OpenClaw . The heartbeat mechanism allows the Agent to periodically "wake up" and execute some background checks and maintenance tasks without user-initiated sessions. This is similar to the robot's automatic timed inspection — the Agent can quietly complete memory organization, status checks, and other work in the background.

- Working Principle

The OpenClaw gateway periodically checks the content of the HEARTBEAT.md file to decide whether to trigger the Agent's heartbeat API call:

- **File is empty or contains only comments:** Skip heartbeat call, Agent will not be awakened in the background

Note

 In the factory configuration, the heartbeat mechanism is disabled by default.

7. TOOLS.md

- Function Description

TOOLS.md is the Agent's **localized notes for tool usage** . In the OpenClaw system, "Skills" define the general working methods of tools, while TOOLS.md records the Agent's own unique configurations and personalized settings. Simply put: Skills are instruction manuals (general), TOOLS.md is your personal notes (unique).

- Working Principle

During sessions, the Agent reads both related Skills documents to understand the general usage of tools, and reads TOOLS.md to obtain configurations related to its own deployment environment.

8. USER.md

- Function Description

USER.md is the exclusive file the Agent uses to **understand and remember user information**. If IDENTITY.md is the window for the Agent to know "who I am", then USER.md is the window for the Agent to know "who you are interacting with". It records the user's basic information, preferences, project background, and other contextual information to help the Agent provide more personalized and attentive service.

- Working Principle

During each session startup, the Agent reads USER.md according to the process specified in AGENTS.md. Through this file, the Agent can:

- Know how to address the user (name, form of address)
- Understand the user's timezone, preferences, and other background information
- Remember what the user cares about and projects being worked on

9. MEMORY.md

- Function Description

MEMORY.md is the AI Agent's **long-term memory file** . In OpenClaw's memory system, there are two levels of memory storage:

1.  **Daily Records** (`memory/YYYY-MM-DD.md`): Records raw events and dialogue logs that occur each day, similar to a human's "diary"
2.  **Long-term Memory** (`MEMORY.md`): Essential information extracted from daily records, similar to human "long-term memory" — contains important events, learned experiences, key decisions, and insights

- Working Principle

The loading and use of MEMORY.md follows these rules:

- **Only loaded in main sessions:** When the user directly converses with the Agent, the Agent reads MEMORY.md to obtain long-term memory
- **Self-maintained by Agent:** The Agent can freely read, edit, and update MEMORY.md during main sessions

Note

In actual user experience, you can:

-  **Proactively write important information:** Write content you think the Agent should remember long-term directly into MEMORY.md
-  **Observe Agent's self-maintenance:** After the Agent runs for a period of time, check the content

automatically accumulated in MEMORY.md

-  **Manage memory content:** Regularly check and organize MEMORY.md, remove outdated information to ensure long-term memory remains refined and accurate